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The Suku of southwestern Congo

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Kwango district, Bandundu, Democratic Republic of the Congo

Section Title(S)

CHILD TRAINING AND SOCIALIZATION • MALE CIRCUMCISION

Circumcised Boys

This is during the period of seclusion. The boys live in the hut in the background at this time.

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MALE CIRCUMCISION

Though a boy's journey into manhood is gradual and without definite landmarks as far as the learning of tasks is concerned, there is one point in it that represents a definite psychological and social break with the past. This is the circumcision ceremony, which at present normally takes place between the ages of ten and fifteen and, in the old days, at eighteen or even later. For the girls, there is no comparable ceremonial.

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A lineage chief in a given region takes the initiative in organizing the ceremony when he feels that there are enough boys of the right age in the area. Participation is entirely unrelated to lineage, clan, or political ties. The ceremony occurs in the dry season, partly for hygienic reasons. The organizer secures the services of a professional circumciser, who must also be knowledgeable in the details of the ceremonial because mistakes are considered to expose the children to witchcraft. The organizer is paid a fee by the parents of each child; out of this money he must pay the circumciser and the professional dancers who provide both entertainment and ritual protection against supernatural dangers for the children.

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Circumcision takes place at early dawn, and the children immediately move to a special hut that has been previously erected outside the village. At present,

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they reside there only a few weeks, since most of them have to return to school in early September; traditionally, the period lasted for several  457 months. During their residence, they learn various dances and songs (most of which are derisive of women) and they are exposed to systematic hazing by their elders. Some of this hazing may border on physical cruelty; much of it consists in forcing the boys into admitting imaginary incestuous relations and making sexual jokes about their parents—behavior that would be unthinkable under normal circumstances. The entire ceremony is believed to ensure the boys' virility. Throughout the period of seclusion, women are strictly forbidden to approach them; those that do so by mistake are fined by the boys. At the end of the period, the boys go to the river, wash themselves, put on new clothing, and return to the village amid dancing and singing. They have now acquired new names and may collect a fine from anyone using their old ones.

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